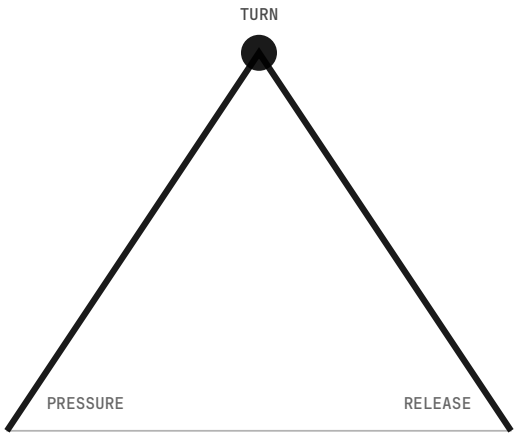
Freytag’s Pyramid

A story earns its turn by building pressure, then releasing it.



BUILD, THEN RESOLVE

WHEN TO APPLY

Explaining a product lifecycle, a multi-year transformation, or any change with an unavoidable peak of pressure.

ARC-01

Freytag’s Pyramid

STRUCTURE

1. Exposition: establish who is involved and what is at stake.
2. Rising action: each attempt raises the cost of failing.
3. Climax: the decision that cannot be taken back.
4. Falling action: consequences arrive faster than remedies.
5. Denouement: the new baseline, stated plainly.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: A flat retelling that lists events in order but never raises the stakes, so the climax arrives with nothing behind it.

Fix: Name the pressure at every beat. If two beats raise the same pressure, one of them is filler.

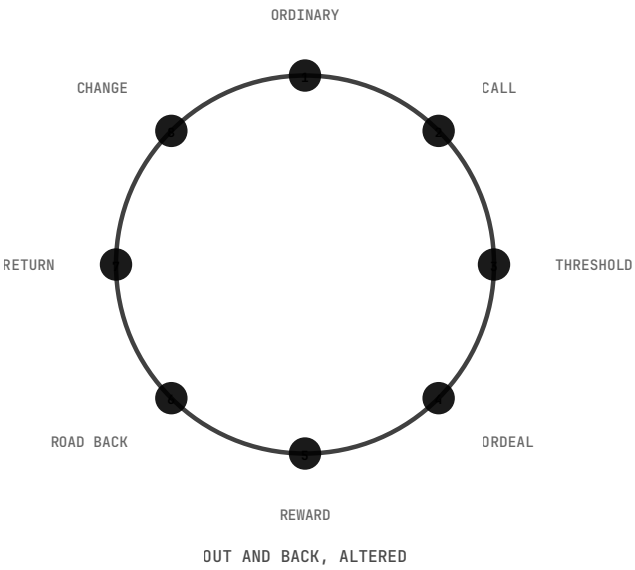
PROMPT

The peak our audience cannot skip past is _____.

Source: Gustav Freytag (1863). *Die Technik des Dramas.* Leipzig.

Hero’s Journey (Monomyth)

An audience follows a protagonist who leaves, is changed, and brings something back.



WHEN TO APPLY

Onboarding journeys, founder stories, and any change that is really someone leaving a familiar state and returning altered.

ARC-02

Hero’s Journey (Monomyth)

STRUCTURE

1. Ordinary world: show what staying costs.
2. Threshold: name what must be left behind.
3. Ordeal: the deepest test, faced without the old tools.
4. Return: bring the change home where it can be seen.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

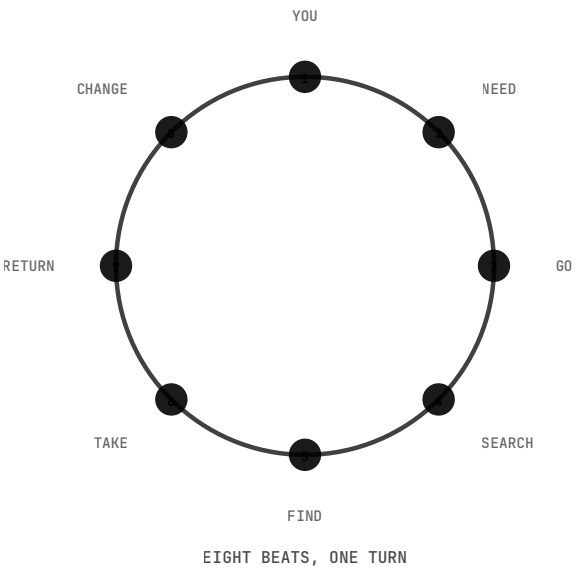
Violation: A journey with no ordinary world, so the audience never learns what the protagonist gave up and the return lands as a shrug.

Fix: Open on the cost of staying. The departure only means something against a life worth missing.

Source: Joseph Campbell (1949). *The Hero with a Thousand Faces.* Bollingen Foundation.

Harmon Story Circle

Comfort, want, discomfort, cost, return: the smallest honest story.



WHEN TO APPLY

Sprint retrospectives, user journey maps, and short case studies where the whole arc has to fit on one slide.

ARC-03

Harmon Story Circle

STRUCTURE

1. Comfort: someone in a zone they know.
2. Want: they reach for something outside it.
3. Go: they cross into unfamiliar ground.
4. Search: effort, adaptation, and its cost.
5. Find: they get what they came for.
6. Take: it costs them something to keep.
7. Return: back to the world they left.
8. Change: the same world, a different person.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

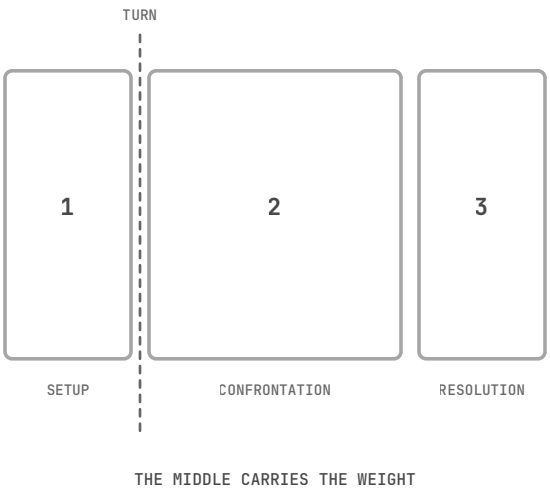
Violation: Using the circle as a checklist of eight headings with no change between the first and last, which is a table of contents, not a story.

Fix: Write the first and last beat side by side. If they describe the same person, the circle has not turned.

Source: Dan Harmon (2000). *Story Circle.* Channel 101.

Three-Act Structure

Something happens, it gets worse, it resolves; give each act its own question.



WHEN TO APPLY

Pitch decks, keynotes, and proposals long enough that the audience needs to know where they are in the argument.

ARC-04

Three-Act Structure

STRUCTURE

1. Setup: the world and the question it cannot answer.
2. Inciting incident: the event that makes staying impossible.
3. Confrontation: obstacles escalate and alliances shift.
4. Midpoint: the protagonist stops reacting and starts choosing.
5. Crisis: the choice between two things they want.
6. Resolution: the world answers the opening question.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

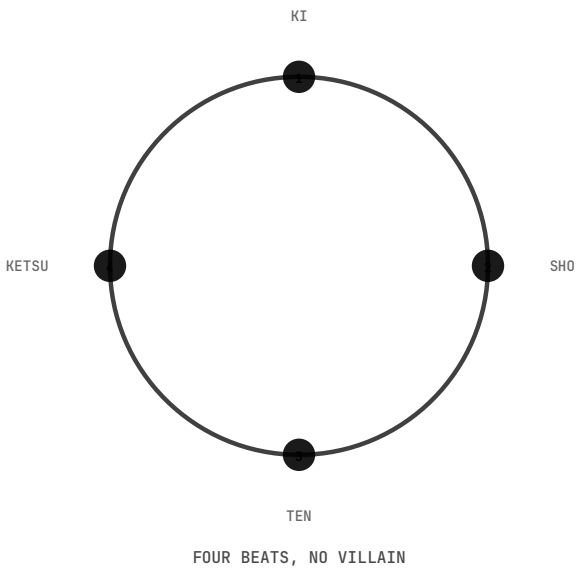
Violation: Three equal acts, because the presenter divided the running time rather than the work, so the middle sags and the end rushes.

Fix: Give the confrontation the most room. Setup states a question; only the middle can make it expensive.

Source: Aristotle (335 BCE). *Poetics*. Greek dramatic theory.

Kishōtenketsu

A twist that reframes what came before needs no villain and no conflict.



WHEN TO APPLY

Product reveals, design retrospectives, and audiences who resist being told there is a problem to defeat.

ARC-05

Kishōtenketsu

STRUCTURE

1. Ki: introduce the subject plainly.
2. Shō: develop it without complication.
3. Ten: a turn that recontextualises everything so far.
4. Ketsu: hold the new reading together without a fight.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: Importing a conflict the material does not have, so a straightforward improvement is dressed as a battle with an enemy.

Fix: Let the turn do the work. If no one opposes the change, the twist is what refreshes attention.

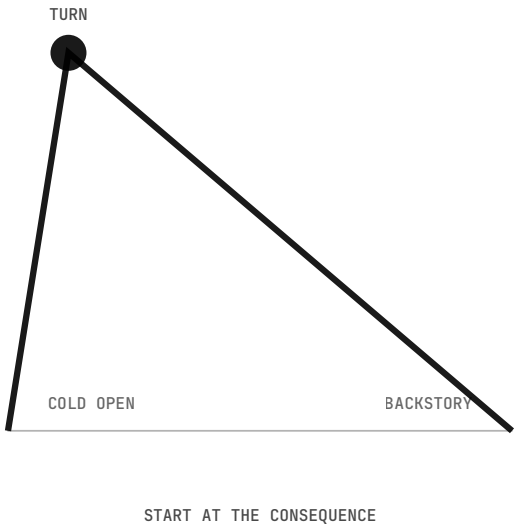
PROMPT

The turn that reframes our subject is _____.

Source: *Kishotenketsu.* Classical Chinese and Japanese narrative tradition.

In Medias Res

Open at the moment of highest consequence, then earn it with the backstory.



WHEN TO APPLY

Incident briefings and executive updates, where the audience's first question is how bad it is, not how it began.

ARC-06

In Medias Res

STRUCTURE

1. Cold open: the consequence, before its cause is known.
2. Rewind: trace how the situation was built.
3. Rebuild tension: let the audience see the mistake forming.
4. Return: reach the opening moment, now understood.
5. Resolution: settle what the cold open left hanging.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

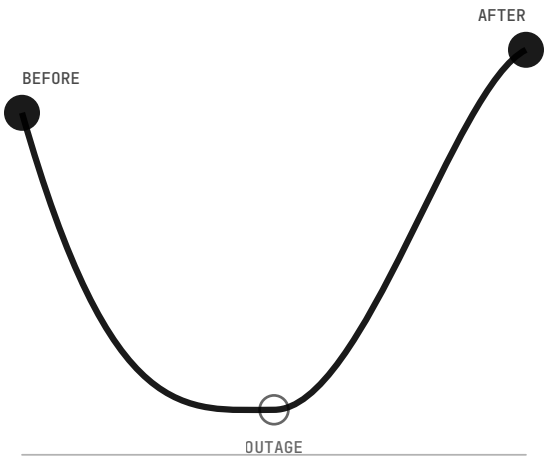
Violation: Opening mid-crisis and never returning to it, so the flash-forward reads as a dropped thread rather than a promise.

Fix: The cold open is a debt. Name the moment it promises, and come back to it before the end.

Source: Horace (13 BCE). *Ars Poetica.*

Man in a Hole

State the depth first; recovery is only credible if the fall was.



THE HOLE COMES FIRST

WHEN TO APPLY

Outage write-ups, security incidents, and turnaround plans where the audience already knows something went wrong.

ARC-07

Man in a Hole

STRUCTURE

1. Baseline: the state everyone expected to hold.
2. Entrapment: the event that removes the easy options.
3. Bottom: name the cost without softening it.
4. Remediation: the specific work that changes the path.
5. Higher baseline: the state that is now possible.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

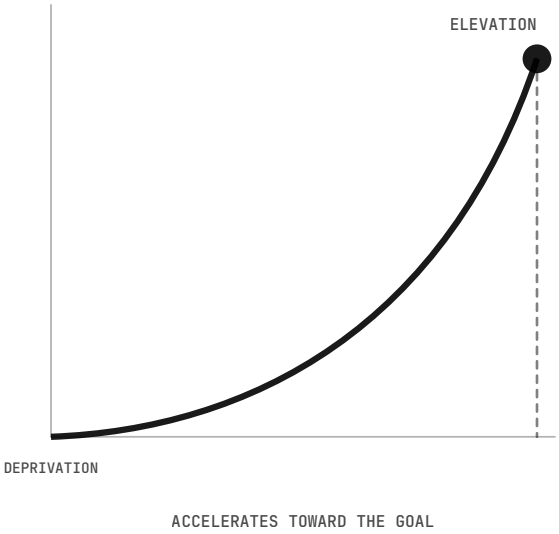
Violation: A hole so shallow that the recovery looks like normal operation, leaving the audience unsure why the incident mattered.

Fix: Quantify the bottom in the audience's terms. Recovery reads as an achievement only against a real depth.

Source: Kurt Vonnegut (1981). *Palm Sunday.* Delacorte Press.

Rags to Riches

Show the starting deprivation in the audience's own terms, then climb without skipping.



WHEN TO APPLY

Account expansion case studies, bootstrap histories, and adoption stories where the starting point is the credibility.

ARC-08

Rags to Riches

STRUCTURE

1. Deprivation: the constraint, measured.
2. Catalyst: the first decision that could compound.
3. Ascent: visible progress, each step built on the last.
4. Barrier: the point where the old method stops working.
5. Elevation: the new state, held and repeatable.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

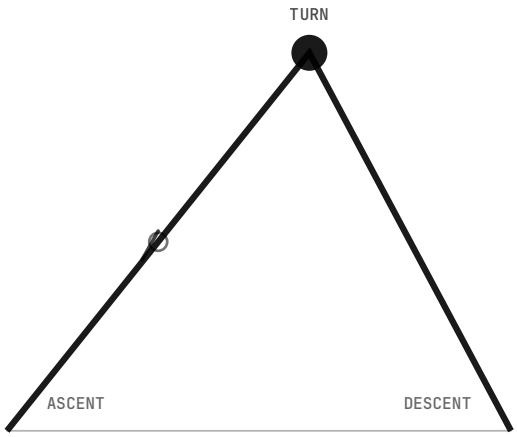
Violation: Starting at the first success, so the audience never sees the constraint the method actually removed.

Fix: Open on a number from before. A climb with no recorded baseline is a brochure.

Source: Vladimir Propp (1928). *Morphology of the Folktale.*

Icarus Narrative

Warn by showing the ascent that felt right, then the boundary it crossed.



THE WAX WAS THE STRATEGY

WHEN TO APPLY

Technical-debt reviews, growth retrospectives, and any warning where the audience is proud of the thing being criticised.

ARC-09

Icarus Narrative

STRUCTURE

1. Premature optimism: the shortcut that looked like speed.
2. Rapid ascent: the results that made it look wise.
3. Boundary breach: the assumption that was never true.
4. Rapid descent: the cost, arriving faster than the gain did.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: Delivering the warning from the ground, so the audience hears a lecture instead of recognising their own ascent.

Fix: Let the rise be genuinely attractive before the fall. The warning lands when the audience remembers choosing it.

PROMPT

The boundary we are not checking is _____.

Source: Ovid (8). *Metamorphoses.*

Cinderella Arc

A brief reprieve that is taken away makes the final elevation feel earned.



WHEN TO APPLY

Seed-to-scale stories, pilot programmes, and validation narratives where the first success did not hold.

ARC-10

Cinderella Arc

STRUCTURE

1. Deprivation: the baseline with no room to move.
2. Transient aid: help that is real but temporary.
3. Reversion: the test that sends the story back.
4. Enduring elevation: the change that outlasts its helper.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

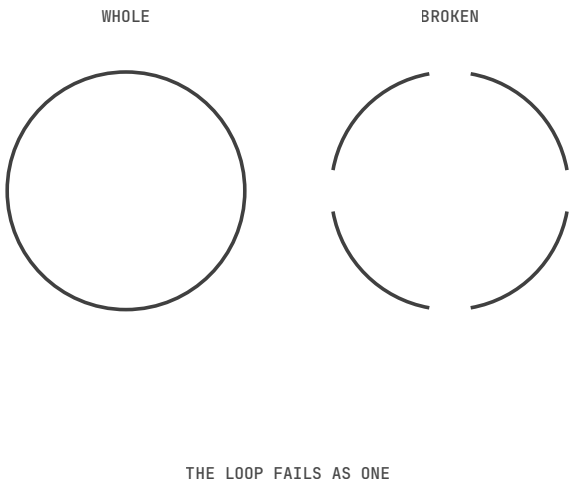
Violation: Cutting the reversion to keep the story upbeat, so the final success looks like luck rather than something tested.

Fix: Keep the setback. The audience trusts an elevation that survived a version of the old problem.

Source: Charles Perrault (1697). *Cendrillon.* Histoires ou contes du temps passe.

Oedipus Arc

The flaw was in the system from the start; revelation is what makes it collapse.



WHEN TO APPLY

Post-mortems of strategic miscalculations, where the audience needs to see that the cause predates the failure.

ARC-11

Oedipus Arc

STRUCTURE

1. Unrecognised flaw: the assumption everyone shares.
2. Temporary relief: the workaround that appears to solve it.
3. Revelation: the evidence that the assumption was false.
4. Systemic collapse: everything built on it fails together.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

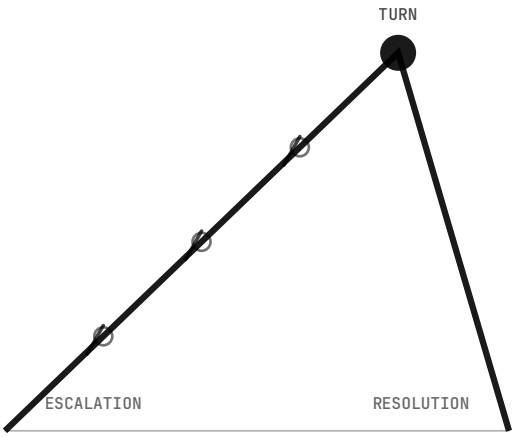
Violation: Naming a villain, which lets the audience conclude that removing one person would have averted the collapse.

Fix: Trace the flaw to a decision the audience would also have made, then show what it was load-bearing for.

Source: Sophocles (429 BCE). *Oedipus Tyrannus.*

The Fichtean Curve

Skip the setup; let a series of escalating crises carry the audience up.



CRISES, THEN THE CLIMAX

WHEN TO APPLY

High-volatility scaling narratives, change-management briefings, and talks where attention must be earned every minute.

ARC-12

The Fichtean Curve

STRUCTURE

1. Setup: the minimum the audience needs to follow a crisis.
2. Crisis one: a small failure with a visible cost.
3. Crisis two: a larger failure that closes an option.
4. Crisis three: the failure that forces the real decision.
5. Climax: the choice made under the accumulated pressure.
6. Resolution: brief, and only what the climax changed.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

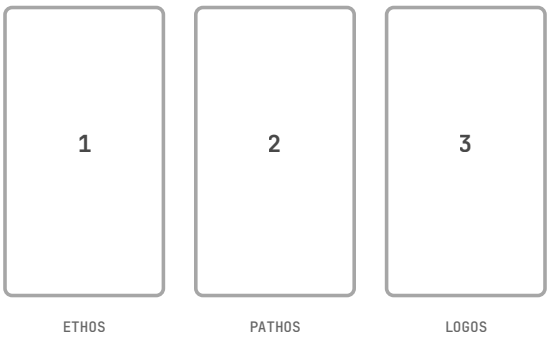
Violation: Escalating the stakes without changing their kind, so the third crisis lands as the first one, louder.

Fix: Each crisis should remove an option the previous one left open. Volume is not escalation.

Source: *The Fichtean Curve.* Modern fiction craft, after Fichte.

Aristotle’s Rhetorical Triangle

An argument needs credible ground, an audience that feels it, and a reason it follows.



WHEN TO APPLY

Board briefings and stakeholder memos, where being right is not yet being persuasive.

PRS-01

Aristotle’s Rhetorical Triangle

STRUCTURE

1. Ethos: say what gives you standing on this question.
2. Pathos: name what the audience loses or gains.
3. Logos: show the reasoning and the evidence behind the ask.
4. Rebalance: strengthen the weakest of the three.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

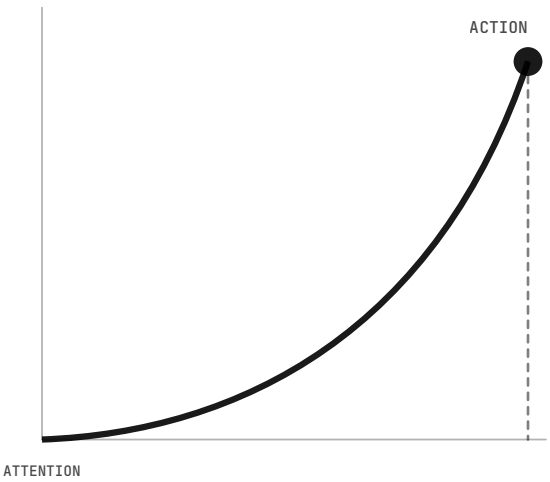
Violation: A deck of evidence with no speaker credibility and no stake for the audience, which is a report rather than an argument.

Fix: Add the missing corner before adding more evidence. Each corner answers a different objection.

Source: Aristotle (350 BCE). *Rhetoric.* Greek rhetorical theory.

Monroe’s Motivated Sequence

Attention is earned, need is argued, and action is asked for by name.



WHEN TO APPLY

Sales pitches and budget approvals, where the audience must leave with a specific next step.

PRS-02

Monroe’s Motivated Sequence

STRUCTURE

1. Attention: a fact or moment the audience cannot ignore.
2. Need: the problem that fact exposes, in their terms.
3. Satisfaction: the mechanism that resolves it.
4. Visualisation: what life looks like once it does.
5. Action: the exact step, owner and date.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: Ending on a summary instead of an ask, so a convinced audience leaves with nothing specific to do.

Fix: Write the ask first. If it has no owner and no date, the pitch has not finished.

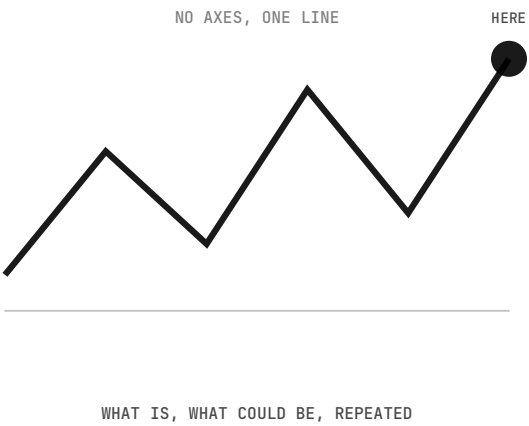
PROMPT

The one action we want is _____, owned by _____.

Source: Alan H. Monroe (1935). *The Motivated Sequence.* Purdue University.

Duarte’s Sparkline

Alternate what is with what could be until the audience prefers the second.



WHEN TO APPLY

Visionary keynotes and strategic realignments, where the case is a change of direction rather than a fix.

PRS-03

Duarte's Sparkline

STRUCTURE

1. What is: the current state, plainly.
2. What could be: the alternative, vividly.
3. Repeat: alternate the two, raising the contrast each turn.
4. New bliss: land on the future and stop there.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

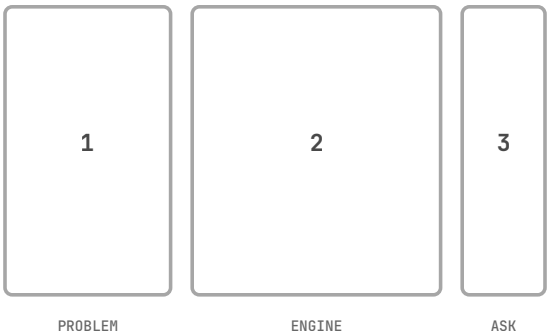
Violation: Spending the talk on the present and flashing the future in one closing slide, so the contrast never builds.

Fix: Count the turns. A change of direction needs the future stated at least as often as the present.

Source: Nancy Duarte (2010). *Resonate.* Harvard Business Review Press.

The Pitch Canvas

An investor buys the problem, the engine and the edge, in that order.



THE ASK IS THE SMALLEST BLOCK

WHEN TO APPLY

Seed and Series A presentations, where the audience is deciding whether the opportunity is real.

PRS-04

The Pitch Canvas

STRUCTURE

1. Problem: who hurts, and what they do instead today.
2. Solution: the smallest thing that removes the hurt.
3. Engine: how demand arrives and how it compounds.
4. Advantage: why this is hard to copy.
5. Ask: the amount, the milestone it buys, and the risk it retires.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

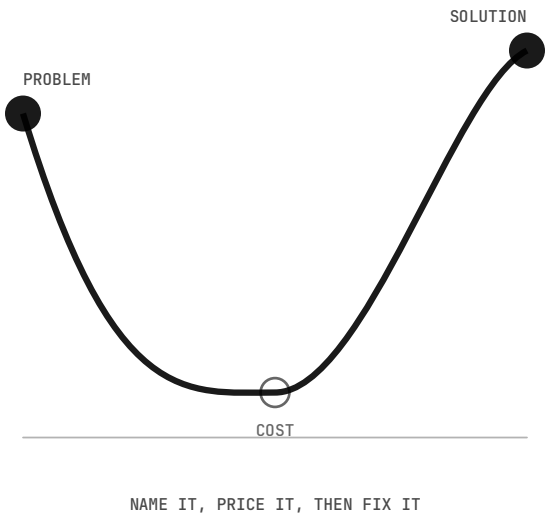
Violation: A product tour where the problem is assumed and the engine is a slide of logos, leaving the investor to infer the business.

Fix: Open on the problem and close on the ask. The middle exists to make the ask cheaper to believe.

Source: Ash Maurya (2010). *Lean Canvas.* Lean Startup movement.

Problem-Agitation-Solution (PAS)

A solution is only as valuable as the problem the audience has just felt.



WHEN TO APPLY

Executive summaries and sales cadences where the reader is already busy and already sceptical.

PRS-05

Problem-Agitation-Solution (PAS)

STRUCTURE

1. Problem: name it in the reader's own vocabulary.
2. Agitation: show the cost of the problem continuing.
3. Solution: the specific mechanism that stops the cost.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: Agitating with fear the reader does not share, which reads as manipulation and closes the door.

Fix: Agitate with their numbers, not yours. The cost must be one they already recognise.

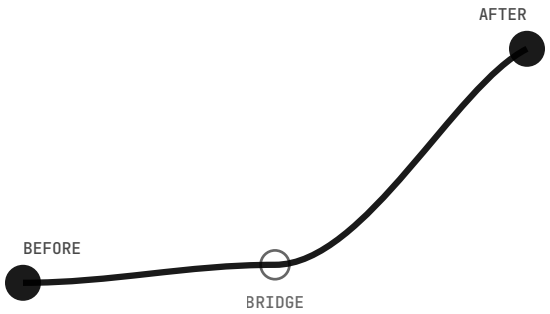
PROMPT

The cost of leaving our problem in place is _____ per _____.

Source: *Problem-Agitation-Solution.* Direct-response copywriting tradition.

Before-After-Bridge (BAB)

Show today, show the day it is fixed, then show the bridge between them.



TWO SCENES AND THE WAY ACROSS

WHEN TO APPLY

Cold outreach, case studies and transformation proposals, where the reader must want the after before hearing the how.

PRS-06

Before-After-Bridge (BAB)

STRUCTURE

1. Before: the current state, including what it costs.
2. After: the same scene, with the cost gone.
3. Bridge: the mechanism that moves one to the other.
4. Proof: who has already crossed it.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

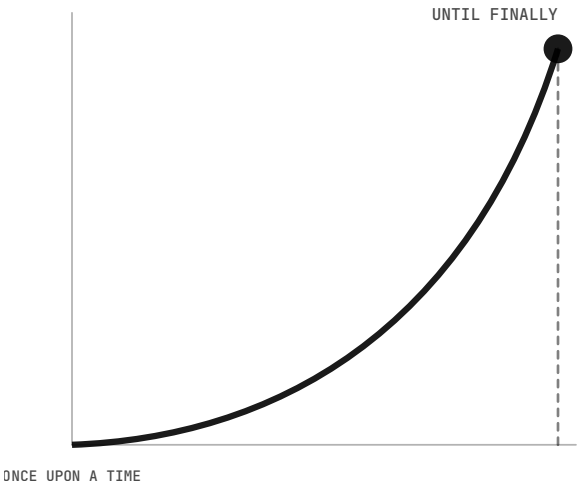
Violation: Describing the after in abstractions the reader cannot picture, so the bridge leads somewhere they do not want to go.

Fix: Write the after as a scene with a person in it. If the reader cannot see themselves there, the bridge is too long.

Source: *Before-After-Bridge.* Direct-marketing copy framework.

The Story Spine

Five clauses turn a status update into a story with a cause and a consequence.



FIVE CLAUSES, ONE CHAIN

WHEN TO APPLY

Sixty-second pitches and investor teasers, where the whole story must fit in one breath.

PRS-07

The Story Spine

STRUCTURE

1. Once upon a time: the world as it was.
2. Every day: the routine that held it there.
3. One day: the disruption that changed the routine.
4. Because of that: the consequences, chained.
5. Until finally: where the chain arrives.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: Filling the clauses with product features, so 'because of that' has no causal force and the spine collapses into a list.

Fix: Each clause must be caused by the one before. If you can reorder them, it is not a spine.

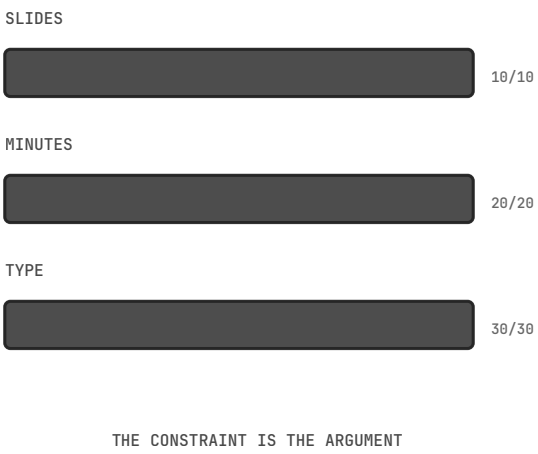
PROMPT

Once upon a time, _____. Every day, _____. One day, _____. Because of that, _____. Until finally, _____.

Source: Emma Coats (2011). *Story Rules.* Pixar.

The 10/20/30 Venture Pattern

Ten slides, twenty minutes, thirty-point type: the constraint is the argument.



WHEN TO APPLY

Formal venture partner meetings, where attention is short and the room has read a hundred decks that month.

PRS-08

The 10/20/30 Venture Pattern

STRUCTURE

1. Ten slides: one idea each, no appendix crutches.
2. Twenty minutes: leave the rest of the hour for questions.
3. Thirty-point type: if it will not fit, it is not the pitch.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

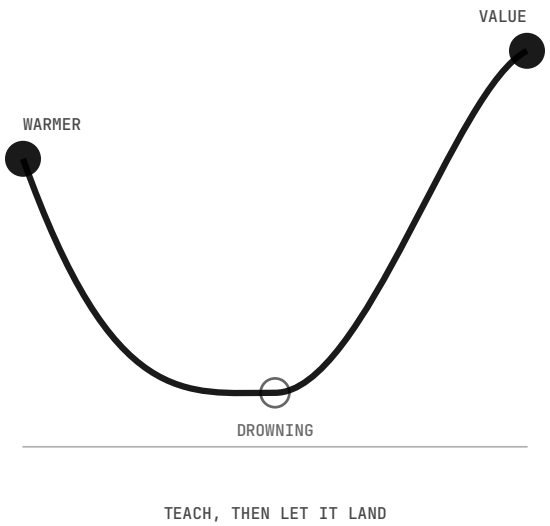
Violation: A forty-slide deck read aloud at speed, which proves the presenter can fill time and not that the idea survives compression.

Fix: Cut to ten slides and move the detail to the appendix. The constraint is a test of the argument, not a style rule.

Source: Guy Kawasaki (2004). *The Art of the Start.* Portfolio.

The Insight-Led Challenge

Teach the buyer something they did not know, then let the implication do the selling.



WHEN TO APPLY

Complex B2B sales conversations, where the buyer believes their current approach is already reasonable.

PRS-09

The Insight-Led Challenge

STRUCTURE

1. Warmer: acknowledge what the buyer already does well.
2. Reframe: a fact that changes how their situation reads.
3. Rational drowning: the cost of the old reading, quantified.
4. Emotional impact: what it means for a person they know.
5. Value: the new approach, stated as their conclusion.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

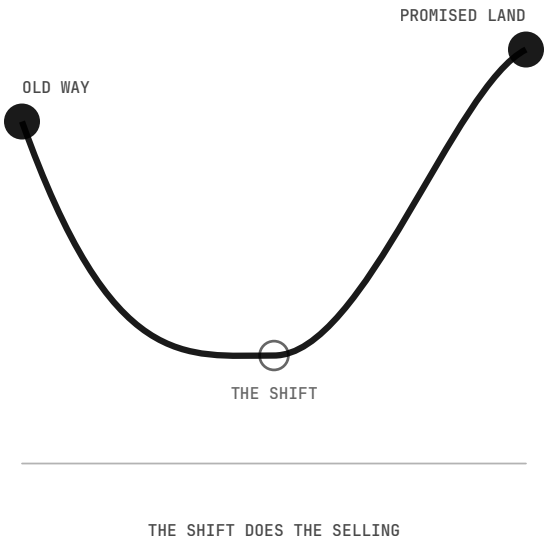
Violation: Leading with the product, so the buyer hears a vendor before they hear an insight and defends the approach they already have.

Fix: Earn the reframe first. If the insight could come from the buyer's own industry, it is not new enough to change a decision.

Source: Matthew Dixon & Brent Adamson (2011). *The Challenger Sale.* Portfolio.

Strategic Narrative Architecture

Name a shift the audience already feels, then make them choose a side.



WHEN TO APPLY

Category creation and enterprise positioning, where the question is not which vendor but which future.

PRS-10

Strategic Narrative Architecture

STRUCTURE

1. Shift: the change in the world that makes the old way obsolete.
2. Winners and losers: what the shift rewards and punishes.
3. Promised land: the state the audience wants to reach.
4. Magic gifts: how this product is the way through.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

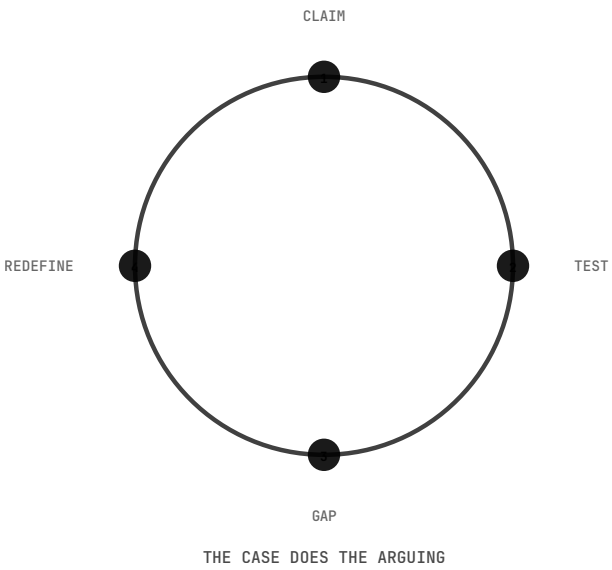
Violation: Declaring a shift the audience has not felt, which sounds like marketing and invites them to argue with the premise instead of the offer.

Fix: Start from evidence they already accept. The shift must be something they could have said themselves.

Source: Andy Raskin (2016). *The Greatest Sales Deck I've Ever Seen.* Medium.

Socratic Elenchus

Ask for the definition, test it against a case, then let the gap argue.



WHEN TO APPLY

Architecture disputes among technical stakeholders who will accept a conclusion they reached and reject one they were handed.

PRS-11

Socratic Elenchus

STRUCTURE

1. Hypothesis: state the other side's position at its strongest.
2. Counter-example: a case the position cannot absorb.
3. Aporia: sit with the gap rather than filling it.
4. Re-definition: a sharper claim that survives the case.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

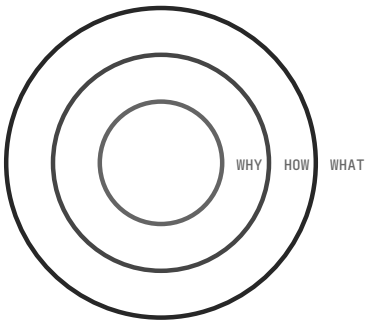
Violation: Using questions as a trap, which works once and costs the room's trust for every conversation after it.

Fix: Argue in good faith and let the other person find the gap. If they do not, the case was not decisive.

Source: Plato (380 BCE). *Dialogues.* Greek philosophy.

The Golden Circle

Lead with why, then how, then what; the order is what makes it land.



THE CENTRE IS THE CLAIM

WHEN TO APPLY

Employer branding and brand positioning, where comparable products compete and the difference is purpose.

PRS-12

The Golden Circle

STRUCTURE

1. Why: the belief the work serves.
2. How: the distinctive way it is pursued.
3. What: the tangible thing that proves both.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

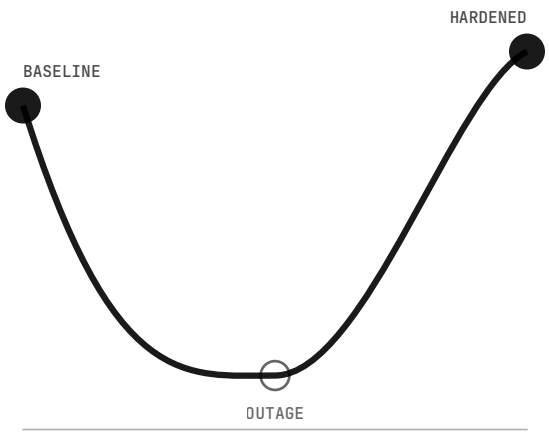
Violation: Starting with what, so the audience compares features before it knows what the features are for.

Fix: Move the what last. It is the evidence for the claim, not the claim.

Source: Simon Sinek (2009). *Start with Why.* Portfolio.

Blameless Post-Mortem Arc

Report the system that failed, never the person who was holding it.



THE FIX OUTLASTS THE INCIDENT

WHEN TO APPLY

Production incident reviews and operational reporting, where the next incident must be cheaper than this one.

COR-01

Blameless Post-Mortem Arc

STRUCTURE

1. Baseline: what normal operation looked like before.
2. Anomaly: the first signal, and when it was visible.
3. Cascade: how one failure reached the next.
4. Remediation: what stopped it, and how long it took.
5. Hardening: the change that makes this cascade impossible.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: A timeline that names the engineer who ran the command, which teaches everyone to write careful timelines instead of honest ones.

Fix: Name the condition that made the command look correct. The fix is in the system, not the person.

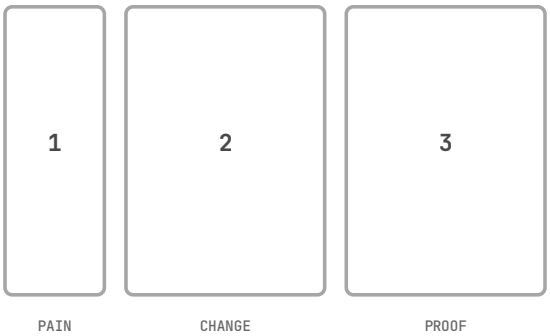
PROMPT

The condition that made the wrong action look right was _____.

Source: John Allspaw (2012). *Blameless PostMortems and a Just Culture.* Etsy Code as Craft.

Product Vision Narrative

Write the launch announcement before the product; if it is dull, stop.



WHEN TO APPLY

New product vetting and zero-to-one allocation, where the decision is whether the outcome is worth funding.

COR-02

Product Vision Narrative

STRUCTURE

1. Headline: the announcement, as the customer would read it.
2. Pain: the current workaround and what it costs.
3. Solution: the change in the customer's day.
4. Quote: a customer describing the benefit in their words.
5. FAQ: the hardest internal objection, answered.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

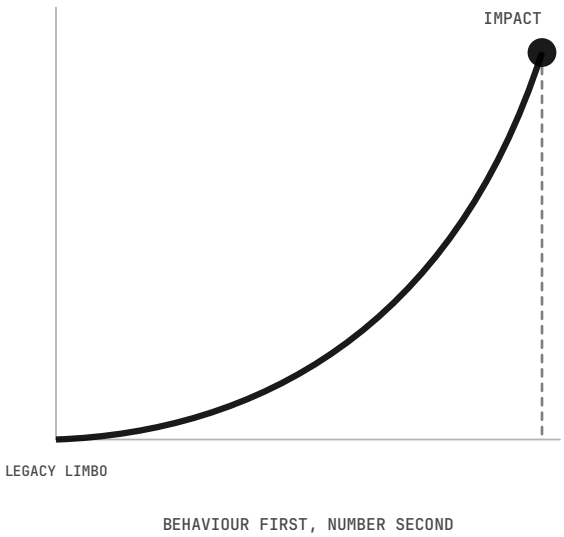
Violation: A press release written for the company instead of the customer, full of internal milestones the reader has no reason to care about.

Fix: Write it in the customer's vocabulary and name what they can stop doing. The internal version is the FAQ.

Source: Jeff Bezos (2004). *Working Backwards.* Amazon product practice.

Customer Success Trajectory

A success story is a change in behaviour, measured after the friction.



WHEN TO APPLY

Customer advocacy decks and retention reviews, where the claim is that the customer now works differently.

COR-03

Customer Success Trajectory

STRUCTURE

1. Legacy limbo: the workaround and its hidden cost.
2. Friction: the moment the old method stopped scaling.
3. Integration: what the customer changed.
4. Behaviour shift: the new routine, visible in their data.
5. Impact: the number that moved, with its baseline.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

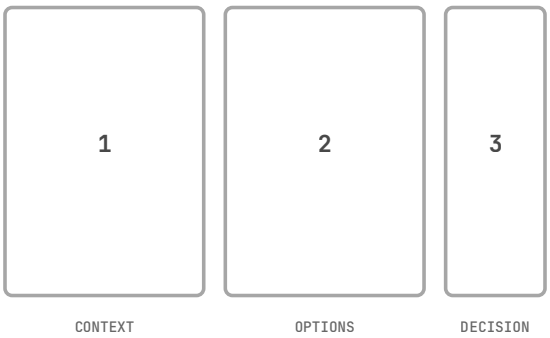
Violation: A quotation without a metric, which shows the customer is happy but not that anything about their work changed.

Fix: Pair every quote with a before-and-after number. A trajectory with no baseline is a testimonial.

Source: Totango (2014). *Customer Success.* Customer Success movement.

Architectural Decision Record (ADR)

Record the options you rejected; the decision will be re-litigated without them.



WHEN TO APPLY

Architecture council submissions and technical governance, where a later engineer will ask why this way.

COR-04

Architectural Decision Record (ADR)

STRUCTURE

1. Title and status: what was decided and whether it holds.
2. Context: the constraints that made a choice necessary.
3. Options: each with its trade-off named.
4. Decision: the one chosen, and by whom.
5. Consequences: what it costs, and how it would be reversed.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

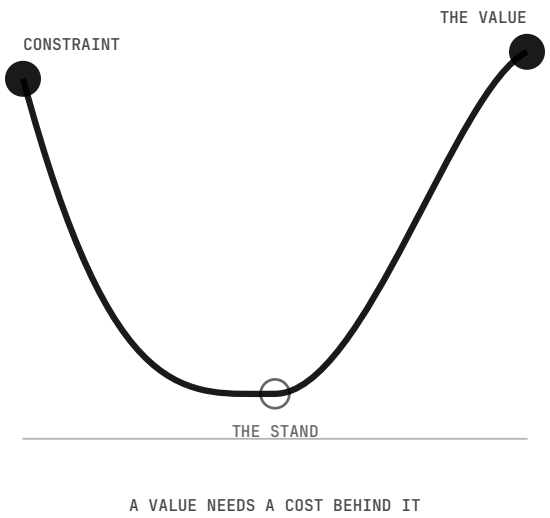
Violation: A record that states the decision and omits the alternatives, so the next team treats it as arbitrary and reopens it.

Fix: Name two rejected options with their reasons. The record is for the person who inherits it.

Source: Michael Nygard (2011). *Documenting Architecture Decisions.* Cognitect.

Enterprise Crucible Myth

Culture is what the organisation did when the cost was real.



WHEN TO APPLY

Culture handbooks and leadership transitions, where stated values need a decision behind them.

COR-05

Enterprise Crucible Myth

STRUCTURE

1. Constraint: the situation that left no easy option.
2. Threat: what the organisation stood to lose.
3. Stand: the decision that cost something to make.
4. Moral: the value it now stands for, in one line.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

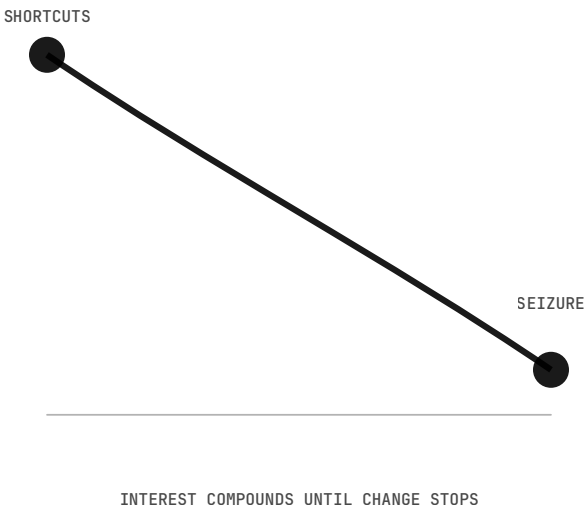
Violation: A list of aspirational values with no story attached, which the reader can neither remember nor test a decision against.

Fix: Attach one real decision to each value. A value with no cost attached is a preference.

Source: Edgar Schein (1985). *Organizational Culture and Leadership.* Jossey-Bass.

Technical Debt Reckoning

Shortcuts accrue interest quietly until the system cannot absorb its own change.



WHEN TO APPLY

Refactoring proposals and engineering re-allocation, where velocity has slowed and no one agrees why.

COR-06

Technical Debt Reckoning

STRUCTURE

1. Accrued shortcuts: the decisions that bought speed.
2. Drag: the recurring cost each one now adds.
3. Seizure: the change the system can no longer absorb.
4. Blueprint: the refactor sequence and what it unblocks.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

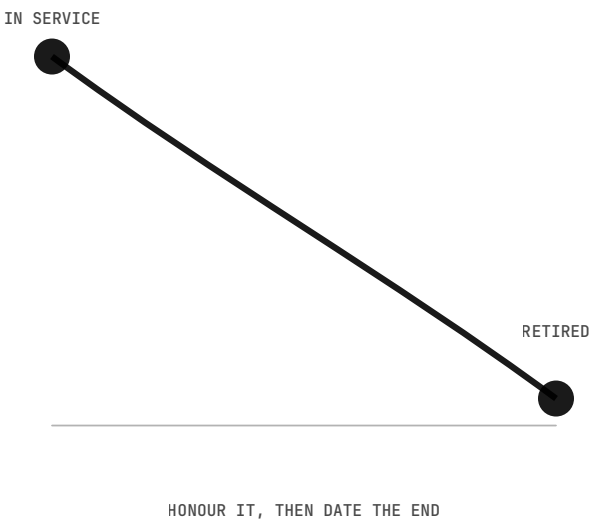
Violation: Calling all code you did not write debt, which turns a specific argument about interest into a taste dispute.

Fix: Price the interest: name the change that is now slow or impossible, and how often it comes up.

Source: Ward Cunningham (1992). *The WyCash Portfolio Management System.* OOPSLA.

Sunset & Deprecation Eulogy

Retire a system by honouring what it did and dating its replacement.



WHEN TO APPLY

System retirement briefings and API deprecation notices, where users must migrate rather than stall.

COR-07

Sunset & Deprecation Eulogy

STRUCTURE

1. Legacy: what the service has carried, stated with respect.
2. Incompatibility: the specific capability it cannot gain.
3. Migration: the path, with owners and a date.
4. Decommission: what stops, and when it is safe to stop.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

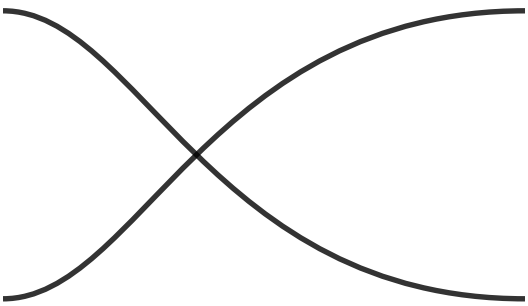
Violation: An announcement that the system is old, with no migration path, which leaves every caller to invent their own schedule.

Fix: Date the shutdown and publish the replacement route. Respect for the legacy buys the migration window.

Source: Gene Kim (2013). *The Phoenix Project.* IT Revolution.

M&A Integration Thesis

Two trajectories meeting is a plan only where the cultures already overlap.



TWO PATHS, ONE AFTER THE CROSSING

WHEN TO APPLY

Mergers, acquisitions and internal reorganisations, where the synergy case must survive contact with two cultures.

COR-08

M&A Integration Thesis

STRUCTURE

1. Trajectories: what each side does well alone.
2. Intersection: the specific work neither can do without the other.
3. Friction: where the two operating models disagree.
4. Unified platform: the single way of working, and who owns it.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

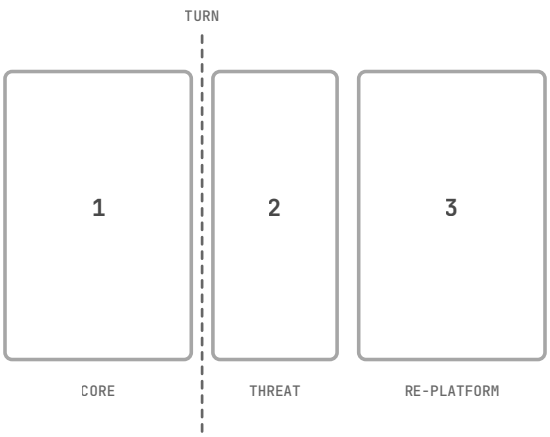
Violation: A synergy spreadsheet with no operating model, so the number is plausible and the first quarter of joint work is spent negotiating process.

Fix: Name the friction before the value. The integration plan is the answer to the culture question.

Source: *M&A Integration Thesis.* Corporate strategy practice.

Digital Transformation Arc

The core business funds the threat it cannot answer; give the answer its own room.



THE CORE FUNDS ITS OWN REPLACEMENT

WHEN TO APPLY

Enterprise transformation updates and board reporting, where the current business is both the sponsor and the obstacle.

COR-09

Digital Transformation Arc

STRUCTURE

1. Dominance: the core business and its margins.
2. Threat: the new model growing at the edge.
3. Skunkworks: the protected unit allowed to compete.
4. Re-platform: the core moved onto what the unit proved.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

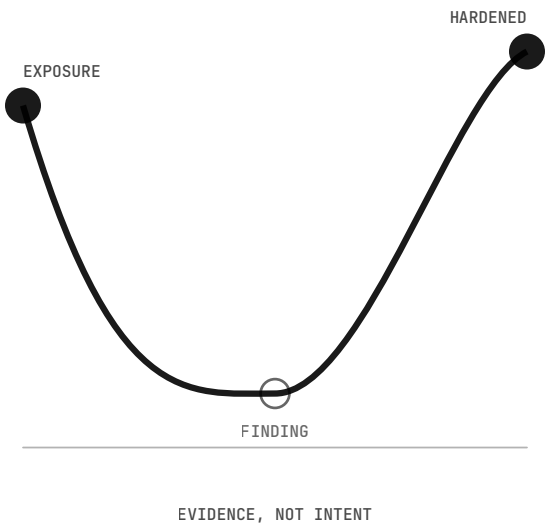
Violation: Housing the new model inside the core's roadmap, where it is ranked against the thing it is meant to replace and always loses.

Fix: Give the new model its own metric and its own P&L. Protection is the only thing that buys it time.

Source: Clayton Christensen (1997). *The Innovator's Dilemma.* Harvard Business Review Press.

Regulatory Compliance Crucible

An audit finds the controls you believed in, not the ones you documented.



WHEN TO APPLY

Audit committee defence and compliance budget requests, where the exposure is real and the evidence is thin.

COR-10

Regulatory Compliance Crucible

STRUCTURE

1. Exposure: the obligation and what non-compliance costs.
2. Audit shock: the finding that shows the gap.
3. Mobilisation: the cross-functional work that closes it.
4. Hardened control: the evidence that now exists by default.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: A policy document offered as evidence of control, which an auditor reads as intent rather than operation.

Fix: Show the control running: a log, a test, a ticket. Documentation describes; evidence proves.

Source: *Regulatory Compliance Crucible.* Financial and healthcare audit practice.

The Innovation Horizon Brief

Fund three horizons at once or the third one quietly disappears.



THREE HORIZONS, ONE BUDGET

WHEN TO APPLY

Annual R&D allocation and innovation reviews, where the current business always wins the budget argument.

COR-11

The Innovation Horizon Brief

STRUCTURE

1. Horizon one: keep the core running and efficient.
2. Horizon two: expand what already earns.
3. Horizon three: options that could replace both.
4. Balance: a protected share for each, reviewed on its own terms.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

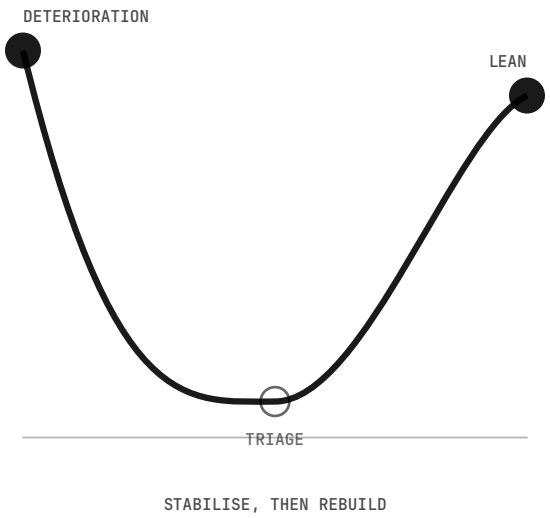
Violation: Judging horizon three by horizon one's payback period, which guarantees it is cut before it can produce anything.

Fix: Give each horizon its own metric and a protected share of the budget. A single yardstick eliminates the future.

Source: Mehrdad Baghai, Stephen Coley & David White (2000). *The Alchemy of Growth.* Perseus.

Turnaround Restructuring Thesis

Stabilise cash first; strategy is a luxury the balance sheet buys you.



WHEN TO APPLY

Turnaround memos and distressed unit reviews, where the audience is deciding how much time exists.

COR-12

Turnaround Restructuring Thesis

STRUCTURE

1. Deterioration: how the unit reached its current position.
2. Triage: what stops the cash bleed this quarter.
3. Realignment: the assets and lines that no longer fit.
4. Lean operation: the cost base the new shape can carry.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: Opening with a new strategy while the cash runway is under a quarter, which the board reads as denial.

Fix: Sequence triage before strategy. Name the week the bleeding stops, then the plan that follows.

Source: *Turnaround Restructuring Thesis.* Corporate restructuring practice.

The In Medias Res Hook

Start inside the consequence; explanation can wait for attention.



WHEN TO APPLY

Slide one and the executive summary, where the reader may stop after the first line.

MIC-01

The In Medias Res Hook

STRUCTURE

1. Open on a consequence already in motion.
2. Withhold the cause for exactly one beat.
3. Rewind only as far as the cause.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

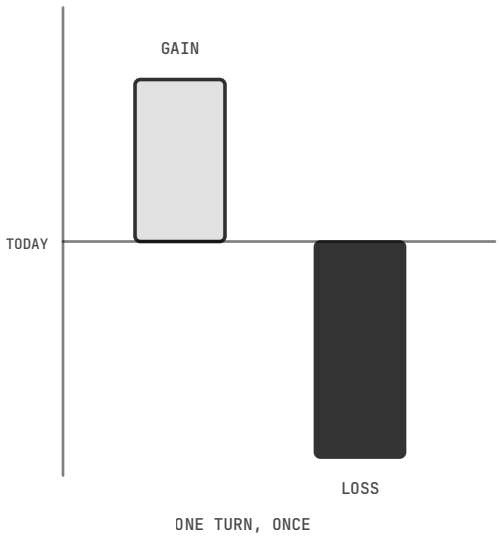
Violation: A hook that promises drama the rest of the document does not pay off, which spends trust the first page cannot repay.

Fix: Make the opening a moment the body explains. If the body cannot, the hook was decoration.

Source: Homer (750 BCE). *Iliad.* Greek epic tradition.

Polarity Shift (Contrast & Tension)

Change the sign of the sentence; the audience feels the drop before the numbers.



WHEN TO APPLY

Slides making urgency felt, where a flat list of risks has stopped registering.

MIC-02

Polarity Shift (Contrast & Tension)

STRUCTURE

1. Establish the positive state in one clause.
2. Turn it in the next clause, without a hedge.
3. Quantify what the turn costs.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

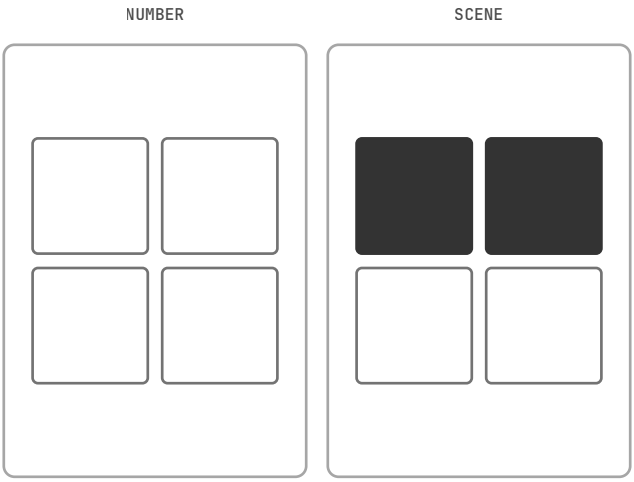
Violation: A turn in every sentence, which stops reading as contrast and starts reading as alarm.

Fix: Spend the shift once, at the point where the decision changes. Repeating it flattens it.

Source: Robert McKee (1997). *Story.* ReganBooks.

Sensory Detail Anchoring

Give an abstract number a body: a wait, a click, a room.



TWO CODINGS, ONE MEANING

WHEN TO APPLY

Explaining latency, scale or KPI movement to an audience that does not work with the number.

MIC-03

Sensory Detail Anchoring

STRUCTURE

1. Name the abstraction and its unit.
2. Place it in a scene the audience has lived.
3. Return to the number, now felt.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

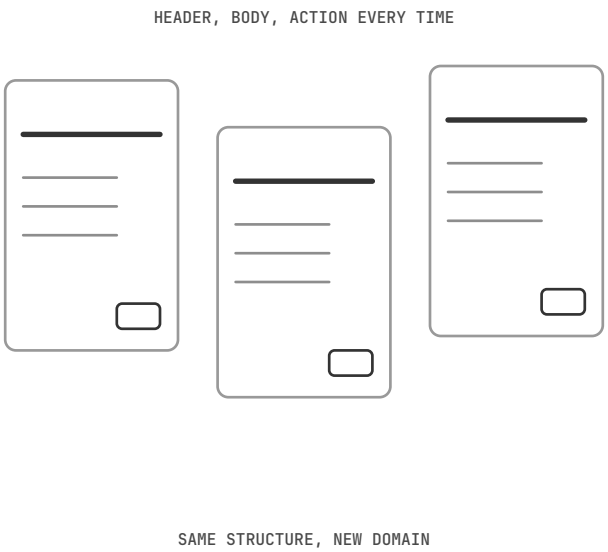
Violation: A metaphor that is vivid but maps the wrong quantity, so the audience remembers the picture and the wrong size.

Fix: Keep the mapping one-to-one. If the scene has two scales, it will teach the wrong one.

Source: Allan Paivio (1971). *Imagery and Verbal Processes.* Holt, Rinehart and Winston.

Metaphorical Bridge

Map the unfamiliar onto something the audience already operates.



WHEN TO APPLY

Explaining a technical mechanism whose structure the audience already knows from somewhere else.

MIC-04

Metaphorical Bridge

STRUCTURE

1. Name the target concept and its hard part.
2. Choose a source domain with the same structure.
3. Map each part explicitly, and name where the mapping breaks.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

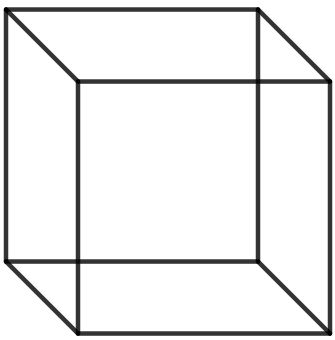
Violation: A metaphor carried past the structure it shares, so the audience reasons correctly inside it and wrongly outside.

Fix: State the boundary. 'It is like X, except Y' keeps the model useful past the diagram.

Source: George Lakoff & Mark Johnson (1980). *Metaphors We Live By*. University of Chicago Press.

Anagnorisis (The Aha-Moment)

The insight lands when the audience sees two readings were one figure.



ONE FIGURE, TWO READINGS

WHEN TO APPLY

Research reveals and strategic unveilings, where the conclusion must feel discovered rather than asserted.

MIC-05

Anagnorisis (The Aha-Moment)

STRUCTURE

1. Show the figure the audience already reads one way.
2. Add the evidence that makes the other reading visible.
3. Let the shift happen; do not narrate it.
4. Name the consequence of the new reading.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

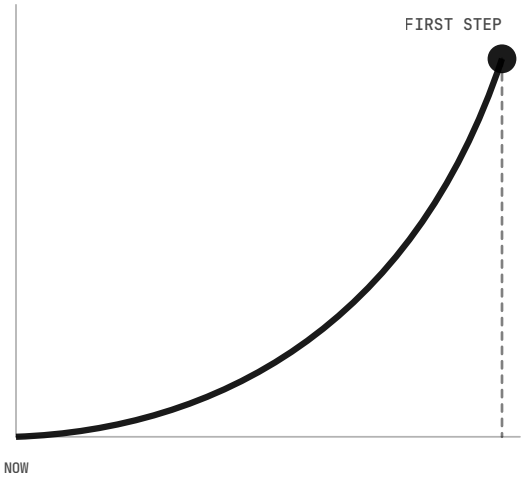
Violation: Announcing the insight before the evidence, which turns a discovery into a claim the audience now argues with.

Fix: Withhold the conclusion until the second reading is available. The order is the effect.

Source: Aristotle (335 BCE). *Poetics*. Greek dramatic theory.

The Call to Adventure

End on one imperative the audience can start before the room empties.



ONE ARROW, ONE FIRST STEP

WHEN TO APPLY

Closing slides and all-hands conclusions, where agreement exists but nothing has been asked for.

MIC-06

The Call to Adventure

STRUCTURE

1. Point at the goal in one sentence.
2. Name the first step, small and specific.
3. Say who owns it and when.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

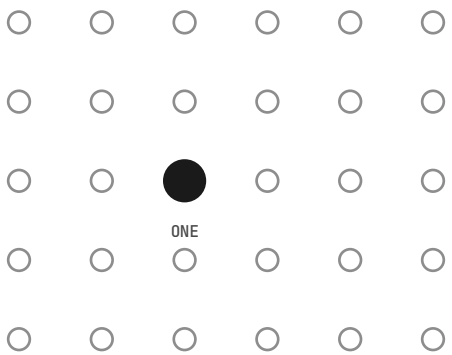
Violation: A closing slide of thanks, which converts a prepared audience into a dispersed one.

Fix: Replace thanks with the first step. Gratitude is a mood; a call is a move.

Source: Joseph Campbell (1949). *The Hero with a Thousand Faces.* Bollingen Foundation.

Identifiable Victim Effect

A statistic moves policy; one person moves an audience.



ONE FIGURE CARRIES THE NUMBER

WHEN TO APPLY

Funding cases for accessibility, safety or user experience, where the aggregate number has stopped persuading.

MIC-07

Identifiable Victim Effect

STRUCTURE

1. State the aggregate, with its source.
2. Introduce one person inside it, briefly and factually.
3. Return to the aggregate: this person is one of the number.
4. Ask for the change that would have helped them.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

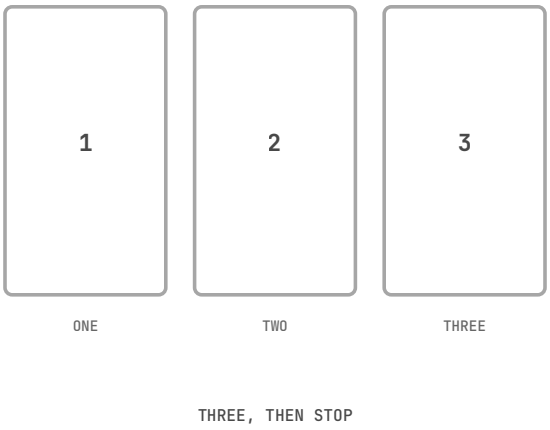
Violation: Using a story as a substitute for the number, so the audience commits to a case rather than to a policy.

Fix: Pair the person with the proportion. The story is the door; the number is what the door opens onto.

Source: Thomas Schelling (1968). *The Life You Save May Be Your Own.* Public Interest.

Tricolon (Rule of Three)

Three clauses make a pattern, a rhythm and a stop.



WHEN TO APPLY

Speechwriting, mission statements and value definitions, where a line must be repeated out loud.

MIC-08

Tricolon (Rule of Three)

STRUCTURE

1. Choose three items of the same kind.
2. Give them parallel grammatical form.
3. Let the third carry the weight or the turn.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

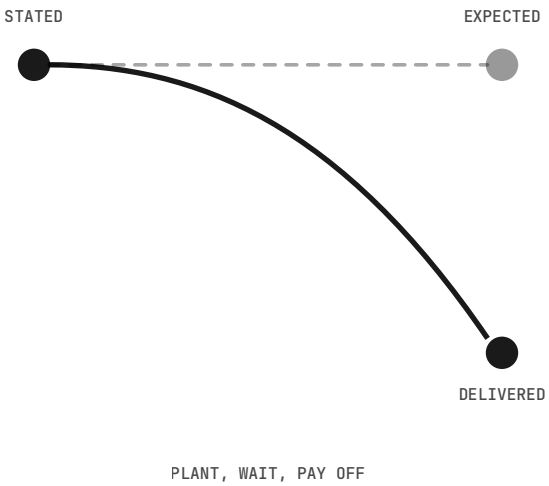
Violation: Three items that are not the same kind, so the pattern promises a shape the list does not keep.

Fix: Check they are the same part of speech and the same level of abstraction. Parallel form is the whole trick.

Source: Cicero (55 BCE). *De Oratore.* Roman rhetorical theory.

Chekhov’s Gun

Plant the detail early that will decide the end, and do not point at it.



WHEN TO APPLY

Strategy narratives and technical differentiators foreshadowed before they matter.

MIC-09

Chekhov’s Gun

STRUCTURE

1. Place the detail where it looks incidental.
2. Leave it unremarked for most of the piece.
3. Let it decide the outcome, and name it only then.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

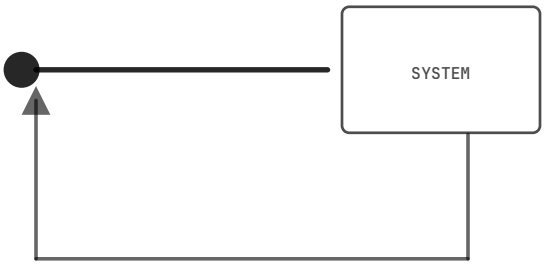
Violation: Planting a detail and then explaining it, which turns foreshadowing into a footnote and removes the payoff.

Fix: Trust the return. If the reader must be reminded, the plant was too quiet or too late.

Source: Anton Chekhov (1889). *Letter to Aleksandr Semenovich Lazarev.* Correspondence.

Zeigarnik Tension Loop

An open question keeps attention that a closed one releases.



OPEN, HOLD, CLOSE

WHEN TO APPLY

Multi-part updates and town halls, where the audience's attention must survive several sections.

MIC-10

Zeigarnik Tension Loop

STRUCTURE

1. Open a question the audience cannot answer yet.
2. Do other work while it stays open.
3. Close it explicitly before introducing the next.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

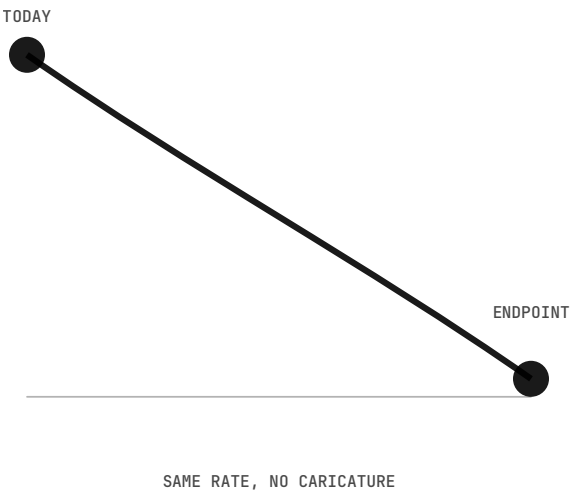
Violation: Opening loops faster than they close, which reads as incoherence rather than suspense.

Fix: Count them. One open question is tension; four is noise.

Source: Bluma Zeigarnik (1927). *On Finished and Unfinished Tasks.* Psychologische Forschung.

Reductio Ad Absurdum

Push the current trajectory to its endpoint and let the endpoint argue.



WHEN TO APPLY

Discrediting inaction or the defence of a legacy system, where the audience believes the status quo is stable.

MIC-11

Reductio Ad Absurdum

STRUCTURE

1. State the current trajectory as its defenders would.
2. Extrapolate it at the same rate, without caricature.
3. Reach the endpoint and stop.
4. Ask what would have to change for the endpoint not to be next.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

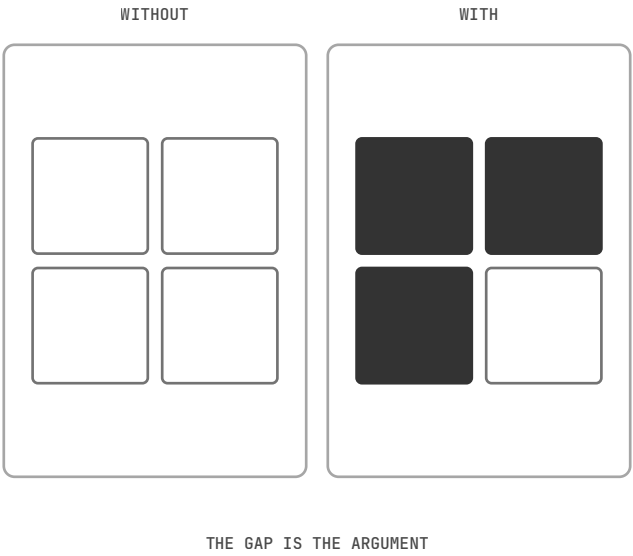
Violation: Extrapolating faster than the trend supports, which lets the audience dismiss the endpoint as a straw man.

Fix: Use the measured rate and say so. The arithmetic should be theirs by the end.

Source: Zeno of Elea (450 BCE). *Paradoxes.* Presocratic philosophy.

The Counterfactual Pivot

Show what would have happened without the work; that gap is the value.



WHEN TO APPLY

Security, risk and compliance ROI cases, where prevention has no visible outcome to point at.

MIC-12

The Counterfactual Pivot

STRUCTURE

1. State what actually happened, with its cost.
2. Describe the counterfactual at the same date.
3. Subtract one from the other.
4. Name the cost of the counterfactual recurring.

ANTI-PATTERN VS REMEDIATION

Violation: Claiming averted incidents that no one can verify, which converts a strong argument into an unfalsifiable one.

Fix: Anchor the counterfactual to evidence: a peer incident, a near miss, a control that fired. Say what is estimated.

Source: Daniel Kahneman & Amos Tversky (1982). *The Simulation Heuristic.* Judgment under Uncertainty.